

# Theological Disputations on the Secunda Secundae of St. Thomas — Disputation VII, Section VIII

Rodrigo de Arriaga, S.J., Lyon 1651 — printed pp. 106–108, marginal nn. 49–56 (English translation)

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## SECTION VIII.

*Whether it is of Faith that this Pope is the true successor of Peter.*

49. That supreme jurisdiction having been established, and the manner in which it ought to be communicated, it can be asked whether it is of Faith that this individual — Innocent X, for example — is the true Pope and successor of Peter. There are various opinions on this point. {marg. *The first opinion denies.*} Some say that this is only by way of a Theological conclusion deduced from one premise of Faith and another morally certain — namely, that Cardinal Pamphili has been elected as successor of St. Peter. {marg. *The second, of Tannerus, affirms.*} But others, on account of the same argument, say that it is of Faith: for what follows from one premise of Faith and another certain one they think to be of Faith. And thus expressly Father Tannerus quæst. 4. num 166. This reasoning, however, I have rejected at length above. {marg. *The third opinion is a middle one.*} Third, others say that it is indeed of Faith that he who has been received by the Church validly exercises all things, just as if he were the true Pontiff: yet that it is not of Faith that he is the true Pontiff. Which opinion in part pleased the same Tannerus, num. 160., insofar as he admits this conditional: *Even if the Pontiff were not in very fact the true Pontiff, nevertheless whatever he defines will truly be of Faith, God supplying such a defect for the good*

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*of the Church:* for which opinion he there cites Bañ. {marg. *It is rejected.*} Deservedly, however, it is commonly rejected, because it plainly seems to involve a contradiction, and to fall into all the arguments which it wishes to avoid: for indeed the foundations for saying that it is of Faith that he validly exercises those offices, or validly defines, are just as slight as those for saying that he is the true Pontiff. Further, to be able validly to exercise those offices, and to be the true Pontiff, is plainly the same thing, unless we abuse words. For a Pontiff is not properly determined to be such by the manner in which he receives the power, but by the power which he has. For if Christ the Lord had established that, without any other Sacraments, by the very fact that he was elected, he should have all the jurisdiction which he now has, assuredly he would then be the same Pontiff that he now is: therefore, since these Authors concede to him the whole jurisdiction, by that very fact they concede that he is the true Pope. I pass over another argument which Father Suarez uses, drawn from this,

that such a one could consecrate validly, though neither a Priest nor baptized: which seems absurd: I pass over it, I say: for it can be said that the true Pontiff does not necessarily require the Sacrament of Order: for he who has been elected, though he be not ordained, is in the opinion of all actually the true Pontiff. This argument therefore being passed over, let the two former suffice.

50. {marg. *The common opinion is pleasing.*} The common opinion is therefore more pleasing, which says that it is altogether of Faith that he who without contradiction and universally has been received by the Church as true Pontiff is the true Pope and successor of Peter: which is defended by Suarius ea sect. 5. and by Tannerus. {marg. *It is proved First:*} It is, moreover, easily urged First, because in the Bull of Martin V at the Council of Constance it is laid down that heretics returning to the Church should believe that the canonically elected Pope who for the time shall be (his name being expressed) is the successor of Peter, &c.; therefore the Council supposes that now, determinately, concerning the present one — for example, Innocent X, his name being expressed — it must be believed that he is the successor of Peter. {marg. *Second.*} Second, because many Councils have determinately acknowledged as such the one who then presided: but there is no greater reason for the one than for the other. {marg. *Third.*} Third, because if it is not established of Faith that Pius IV was the true Pope, neither will it be established that the Council of Trent is valid; because the Council receives its whole force from the Pope. But that is almost heretical. {marg. *Fourth.*} Fourth, because if there is no certain assurance concerning the true Pontiff, neither can there be assurance concerning the true Church, since the Church is most of all recognized through her head. {marg. *A weak proof*} This reason, however, on account of what was said above, pleases me less. For from its doctrine the true Church can be recognized, as it is also recognized when the See is vacant; even if the interregnum should last for two or three or more years. {marg. *It is proved Fifth:*} Fifth, because neither should we be bound to believe the definitions of the Pontiffs, above all in matters which they define anew: as in Canonizations, &c. For if it be not of faith that the Holy Spirit assists him, the things which he proposes to be believed will not be of Faith. Here note the difference between these definitions and the propositions of revelations formerly made: for in the case of those not formerly made it is necessary that the Holy Spirit assist him now proposing the same: because that one does not propose First, but prudently shows that those mysteries were revealed to another: but the Pope often proposes things which the Holy Spirit has revealed to no other, at least in the manner in which they are proposed by him, as we shall say below: therefore we must be certain that he is directed by the Holy Spirit, in order that we may believe that those things are said by the Holy Spirit himself, or at least are uttered with him directing the tongue, lest the Pontiff err. {marg. *Sixth.*} Sixth, because otherwise, whatever is believed as certain of Faith concerning the Judge of Controversies in the Church would be plainly ridiculous: for how am I bound to believe of Faith that such a Judge exists, if I cannot say from Faith who he is? For what purpose, I ask, would such an assent concerning the as it were indeterminate existence of that Judge serve in practice? Surely we should not be bound from Faith to go to the Pope in those Controversies; because anyone would say: faith only teaches me that I am bound to go to the Judge of Controversies; but it does not tell me that he is Ioan. Bapt. Pamphili, or Innocent X; therefore I

am not bound from faith to go to him, or to believe him when he decides. These and other arguments, which can be adduced, efficaciously prove that this is altogether of Faith.

51. {marg. *First principal objection. Response of Suarius. It is refuted First:*} Yet it can be objected to the contrary First, because it is not of faith that he is baptized, ordained a Priest, &c. P. Suarez responds that these conditions do not pertain to Faith, but are as it were Theological conclusions, which are inferred by a certain consecution. I marvel that he employs this solution, since he says that every particular is of faith when the universal is of faith. Whence I argue: This is of Faith, *Every true Pontiff is baptized*: because the contradictory, or contrary, *No one not baptized is a true Pontiff*, is of Faith; therefore this ought to be of Faith, *Therefore this true Pontiff is baptized*, pointing to Pamphili; just as he says that, pointing to Peter, it is of Faith, *This man is mortal*. {marg. *Second, ad hominem.*} Second, Suarez himself rejects those who say that it can be of faith that he validly exercises his offices, though it be not of Faith that he is the Pope. He rejects them, I say, because thence it would follow that someone not a Priest could validly give Orders: which is repugnant to the Faith The same argument I turn back upon him: for if it is not of Faith that he is baptized, while nevertheless it is of Faith that he is Pope: then one not baptized, and consequently not ordained, could be Pope, and validly confer Orders, &c.

{marg. *Our response.*} You see that the argument is universal. I respond therefore to the objection: by the very fact that it is rendered of Faith that he is the successor of Peter, it also becomes of Faith that he is baptized. {marg. *Concerning Orders nothing is asserted here.*} Concerning Orders I say nothing, because (as I have intimated) the whole jurisdiction in which the Papacy properly consists is independent of Order: and just as a true Pope can be for half a year without Orders, he can also be for a whole one.

{marg. *Objection.*} You will press, however: Therefore if he ordains and absolves sacramentally, he can err: which is to the great prejudice of the Church. {marg. *Response.*} I respond that as to this there is perhaps no greater prejudice than if another Bishop or a simple Priest should absolve and ordain: whence I do not judge it to be of Faith that he cannot err in that manner in the very act.

52. {marg. *First principal objection.*} Second, you will object principally: there is nothing whence it may be established that God has revealed that he is Pope: for indeed we showed above that in the general revelation formerly made it is not included, not even implicitly, that Pamphili is Pope: therefore this must be revealed anew: to whom, then, and when was it revealed? not to the Pontiff himself, not to the Church as distinct from him: for she has no universal revelations nor assistance of the Holy Spirit, except by reason of the Pope himself: therefore. {marg. *Response.*} I respond, from what was said above, that God reveals something in two ways: in one, properly speaking, outwardly or inwardly with him to whom he reveals: and in this way we said above that it is not necessary that there be now given in the Church a universal

revelation for believing; in another way, in the exercised act, by not permitting that he who proposes the matter should lie in any way, but by so disposing his intellect by his providence that he touches the truth: in this manner, therefore, I say that God reveals to the Church that this individual Innocent is the true Pontiff: for he does not permit that anyone be proposed to the whole Church undoubtingly as true Pope, except him who really is such. But it is evident to us that he does not permit this, because he promised that he would be present to the Church: which he ought most of all to make good in this point, on which the government of the whole Church and the declaration of the things to be believed depend, according to what was said a little before.

53. {marg. *Through whom God reveals this man to be the true Pontiff.*} But to that question, through whom he reveals it, some respond that it is urged from the valid election: for that being posited, it is now of Faith that he is the true Pontiff. This reasoning, however, does not satisfy; for the whole difficulty will press upon the election itself; for whence shall we know that it is a true and valid election, especially since for its validity many things are required which are purely hidden? namely, that the one elected be baptized; that the Electors be baptized; that the election be not simoniacal, &c. It is better therefore responded that we are assured of that truth, or of the valid election, from the fact that the Cardinals, and the Bishops, and the Clergy, and almost the whole body of the Church accept that election without contradiction. But as to what was said, that, the Pope himself being set aside, God reveals nothing to the Church, a distinction must be made: when the Pope has already been received, and a matter is to be decided by him, then I confess that God has that infallible assistance toward him alone; but in order that the Pope himself be received as such, he must effect this through the Church: whence, by directing her lest she err in such a proposing, he reveals to us in that second way who is the Pope and Head of the Church.

54. {marg. *Rejoinder.*} You will rejoin: Often after a legitimate election and acceptance many have protested, even from among the Electors; therefore the whole Church was not then proposing it: therefore neither were we bound to believe it. {marg. *First response.*} I respond First, that sometimes the validity of the election is at once manifestly established through the common acceptance, though afterwards some protest; in which case the revelation has already been made through the first manifestation and acceptance of the election: and this, once made and promulgated, the Electors cannot revoke, even all of them together; whence then without doubt he remains the true Pontiff. But perhaps for those who are distant from the place of the election there will not yet be so sufficient a proposition of its truth that they be bound to believe it; and they will have to await fuller information: {marg. *In Urban VI the heretics lie that the series of Pontiffs failed.*} so it happened in the election of Urban VI (in whom the heretics lie that the true series of Pontiffs failed;) for since he had been elected by almost all the Cardinals, and had in that very fact much more than the two thirds which suffice for a Canonical election; and since on that account the election had been promulgated and accepted throughout the World: a few days afterwards certain Cardinals, fearing that Pontiff's severe nature, inclined also to punishing certain vices even in the Cardinals themselves, began to protest against that election, and, fleeing into France, elected Clement VII,

from whom that most protracted schism began, in which neither the number of those Cardinals nor their tardy protest could invalidate the juridical election already accepted; whence the successors of Urban were always reputed as altogether legitimate by the greater and better part of the Church down to the times of Gregory, Benedict, and John: {marg. *Gregory, Benedict, and John at the same time each said that he was Pontiff.*} all three of whom called themselves Popes: for then among the right-thinking there was some reason for doubting, above all between Gregory XII and John XXIII; for Benedict had no probable right. Those two, therefore, inasmuch as they had been elected by the greater part of the Cardinals at different times — which was done with good intent for the complete removal of the schism — seemed able to claim a right to the Papacy: therefore we say that at that time it was not of Faith who was the true Pope, &c.; for in the conclusion it was laid down that he must be proposed and accepted without probable contradiction, in order that his election be of Faith. But I understand a contradiction not of some few who may be discontented — for these do not take away the certainty of the election — but a notable one, and of prudent men, and finally one resting on apparent foundations: in a word, a probable one: for then it is lawful for anyone to suspend assent until it be better established who has the right.

55. {marg. *Objection.*} You will say: The same inconveniences seem to follow if at that time it is not certainly established who is Pope, or if a great part of the Church adheres to him who is not really Pope? the same, I say, which would follow if all adhered to him. I deny the supposition: for indeed, when there is such a doubt, those inconveniences, {marg. *First response:*} because in the first place not the whole Church is deceived, but a part. {marg. *Second.*} Second, because even those who are invincibly deceived are nevertheless afterwards, the schism being removed, united to the true Pontiff, and seek from him the confirmation of those graces which they had received from the apparent one; and accordingly by that very fact the danger of irreparable harm and of false dogmas now ceases. And therefore the Pontiffs who afterwards are found undoubtedly and without contradiction are accustomed either to invalidate or to revalidate the things which were done under the schism, as they judge expedient: so that thus every reason for doubting may cease in the Church. As did Martin V, at length legitimately and without any controversy elected, the schism being utterly blotted out. And enough concerning this argument.

56. {marg. *A notable point.*} Yet observe this further: just as for believing all the other truths of the Faith some proposition is necessary which stands by way of application, though not as the formal reason of believing — as the instruction of one's Parish priest, &c. — so in the present case the same is required. For we here at Prague, for example, cannot know what was done at Rome in the election except from letters and report: when therefore this is written so undoubtingly that we are now prudently bound to believe in a human manner, then we shall also be bound to believe with divine Faith that such an individual is Pope, because then there is given a sufficient proposition and credibility of its truth.

{marg. *Doubt.*} You will ask whether he who denies the true Pontiff in the individual is to be judged a heretic, or a schismatic. {marg. *Solution.*} I respond: If when he denies there is some reason for doubting, as there is wont to be in time of schism, perhaps such a one is to be excused from heresy: but if, when the Pope has been universally and without contradiction received as true Pontiff, as now Innocent X, someone should deny that he is the true Pope, assuredly he will be a heretic: otherwise in the same way he could without heresy deny also his predecessor Urban VIII, and Gregory XV, and so of the others — in a word, all of them up to Peter exclusively: whence that principle certain of Faith would be destroyed, that there have been in the Church successors of Peter, Vicars of Christ, visible Heads of the Church, &c.